

VirtualDub

Only if it knew how to win

The best thing about VirtualDub is its range of stop conditions. Stop capture if the capture time, the file size, or the dropped frame ratio exceeds, or the free space drops below a specified limit.

Like others in the fray, VirtualDub lets you apply filters, or rather a sequence of filters, to the capturing process. Its video filter dialog allows you to string together a chain of filters that blur images, re-size the image frame and reduce noise in the captured frame sequentially.

The software puts a lot of stress, and rightly so, on the proper capture of video—capture video minus jitters, noise, etc. To do so, it has a variety of settings such as the noise reduction, field-swapping, cropping, etc.

By default, VirtualDub records in the VCD format. As in iuVCR, you will need to install the appropriate codecs to record in other formats. Sadly, it also does not provide any video compression of its own. A volume meter helpfully gauges the audio input level, and controls the audio level of the recording.

Like iuVCR, VirtualDub names the captured file automati-



VirtualDub has a number of stop conditions as compared to the rest of the gang

cally. It applies a numeric suffix to the filename, which is incremented every time the recording is completed. However, you need to turn this feature after the software is installed.

And yes, it's absolutely free!

Price: Free

Web site: www.virtualdub.org

- + A variety of stop conditions; provides controls to monitor quality and noise
- Does not have video compression

WinDVR

A near miss

Out of its satchel of features, one that is unique to WinDVR is transcoding. This transforms the captured video from MPEG to AVI, and vice-versa. Another of its exclusive assets is its inbuilt support to burn recorded movies onto CDs.

Like PowerVCR, WinDVR lets you have that much-needed control over TV signals. It supports both instant replay, as well as the pause-and-resume functionality for live video. While the instant replay time interval could be anything in the range of 1 to 600 seconds, the time-shifting interval can be any value between 1 to 6,000 minutes.

Another similar feature, is the list of pre-defined profiles such as MPEG-2 Good, MPEG-2 Better and MPEG-2 Best, and a variety of PAL/NTSC recording formats.

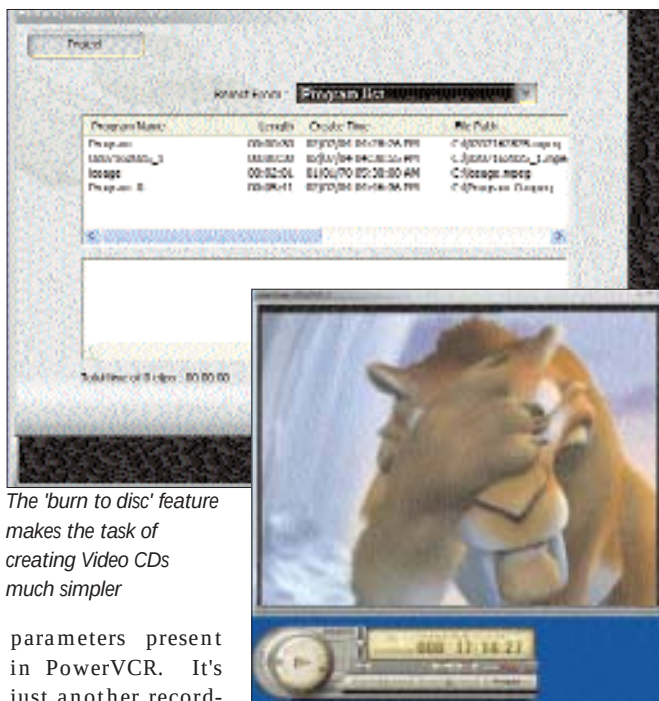
You are bound to get into the habit of skipping commercials using WinDVR. The parameter that makes this possible is completely customisable, and its value can be anything between 1 to 600 seconds.

Apart from features such as snapshot, scheduling, compression and previewing while you record, you can also password-protect adult channels. Incidentally, only WinDVR's developers were thoughtful enough to include this feature.

If you have set up two monitors, you can configure the software to play recorded video on one screen, and a TV signal on the other simultaneously!

You can also specify the minimum space needed by Windows in the worst-case scenario wherein WinDVR starts to hog nearly all the available space to record a signal.

All said and done, WinDVR lacks the advanced recording



The 'burn to disc' feature

makes the task of creating Video CDs much simpler

parameters present in PowerVCR. It's just another recording software that you may want to consider if you have children running around the house.

Price: US\$ 395 (20 users)

Web site: www.intervideo.com/jsp/WinDVR_Profile.jsp

- + Transcoding and burn-to-disc features; live-TV options
- No advance recording parameters such as noise reduction